

Most and almost

Teaching guide

Distinguish a majority from something nearly true.

Understand the distinction

Most before a plural or uncountable noun means the majority or greatest part: most students, most water. Use most of before a determiner or pronoun: most of the students; most of them.

Almost means nearly: almost ready, almost all, almost everyone. It does not normally directly modify a plural noun to mean the majority: say most people or almost all people, depending on your meaning. Almost all is stronger than most.

Compare the patterns

MAJORITY

Most students came.

More than half came; the precise number is unstated.

NEARLY EVERYONE

Almost all the students came.

Very few were absent.

NEARLY A STATE

The room is almost ready.

Some preparation remains.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Correct this: Almost people arrived on time.

2. Complete: Most ___ them agreed.

3. Which suggests a larger share: most / almost all?

Use it in your own life

Describe a group using most, then describe something nearly finished.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. Most people arrived on time.

If nearly everyone arrived on time, use Almost all the people instead.

2. of

Use of before a pronoun such as them.

3. almost all

It means nearly the entire group.

One possible response

Most of my classmates walk to school. Our project is almost finished.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-37.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Describe a group using *most*, then describe something nearly finished.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.